SHATTERFALL

Written by

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EXT. OUTER DISTRICT - NIGHT

A city in ruin. Smoke weaves through hollow towers. The air hums alive with distant gunfire, the moan of broken wind.

Ash falls. Slow. Relentless.

Through it walks RAVI "RAZOR" SHAN, 30s, built from scar tissue and silence. Eyes forward. Movements surgical. A blade disguised as a man.

He stops. Waits. Shadows move in the near distance. ASH COVENANT ENFORCERS shake down a family in a crumbling alley. Screams muffled. Boots striking bone.

Ravi watches. No blink. No twitch. Cold rage trapped under the skin.

A DOG barks from a rooftop. Ravi locks eyes with it.

The dog goes silent.

He kneels. Finds a broken piece of RED CHALK near a child's scrawled mural, crude images of soldiers and burning homes.

Ravi pockets the chalk. Stands. Turns to a tenement swallowed by shadow.

Its door bears a smeared symbol. A triangle bisected by a single red slash. The mark of an ASH BISHOP.

Ravi studies it, unmoving. A faint echo, ALINA'S LAUGHTER, drifts through his mind, fractured and fading.

He presses a hand to the door. Enters.

EXT. NEARBY ROOFTOP - SAME TIME

A figure watches Ravi from the roof. SHADOWED. Tattered robe. Metal glint beneath the cowl.

They whisper into a broken communicator.

GREY VULTURE (V.O.)
Target confirmed. Initiating zero hour.

INT. TENEMENT - CONTINUOUS

Dark. Dripping. The smell of incense and rot.

Ravi climbs a stairwell. Boots whisper. Each step deliberate, ritual, not movement.

At the top, single bulb flickers above a door wrapped in silk and grime. He listens. Three breaths inside. One heartbeat slower than the others.

He kicks the door open.

INT. UPPER ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Luxury amidst ruin. Red silks. Gold plates. Candles burning on skulls.

BISHOP TALARIN, 50s, sits at the head of the table. His eyes like wet coal. He dines on raw flesh, methodical. Two BODYGUARDS flank him.

TALARIN
You should've stayed buried, Razor.

Ravi says nothing.

TALARIN (CONT'D)
We built peace from fire. You just burn without reason.

Ravi steps forward.

RAVI
Fire remembers who lit it.

TALARIN
Sit. For old times. You trained half the Ash Hands. Even the Knife Monk still mimics your form.

Ravi doesn't move.

TALARIN (CONT'D)
She cried for you. That girl. Alina. She thought your name would save her.

Gunfire erupts, Ravi pivots, knives flash. Ravi LAUNCHES.

He STABS a guard in the throat, blood geysers. Uses the body to absorb gunfire. The second guard lunges. Ravi dislocates his jaw with an ELBOW, then stabs him through the ear.

FLASH — RAVI IN WAR — executing prisoners in a burning village.

Ravi slams the shooter into the wall, drives a blade under the jaw. Silence.

FLASH — ALINA SCREAMING — chained. Fire rising behind her.

Talarin rises, slow, confident. He draws a GOLD DAGGER etched with the Covenant sigil. Ceremonial, wicked.

TALARIN (CONT'D)
You took the Oath. You swore to me.

RAVI
I swore to the Code. You burned it.

They clash, brutal, fast, close. Every strike personal. Metal screams against bone.

FLASH — THE CODE being carved into Ravi's forearm. Blood drips. Chanting.

Ravi takes a hit across the ribs. Talarin smiles, blood on his teeth.

TALARIN
She begged for mercy.

Ravi's world narrows, ALINA'S VOICE, laughter twisted into screams.

Ravi disarms him. Drives the dagger into Talarin's chest. Slow. Intimate. Eyes locked.

RAVI
You showed her none.

Talarin collapses. The candlelight dies with him.

Ravi kneels. Opens a small satchel.

Inside: an ASH SCARF, Alina's. Torn. Blood-marked. He wraps it around the dagger's handle.

Lights a single stick of incense. Presses it to the floor.

RAVI (LOW) (CONT'D)
Cleansed.

INT. SHIPPING CONTAINER - NIGHT

Talarin's body sits nailed upright. His robes soaked dark. The room breathes ash.

Ravi lays a steel plate on a table. SIX sigils carved in uneven lines.

He brands over Talarin's mark. Metal hisses. Smoke curls into the shape of the Covenant's symbol before dissolving.

Ravi carves one word beneath the burned sigil: ALINA.

EXT. DOCKYARD - DAWN

Ash sweeps across the shore. Ravi stands alone at the edge, holding the gold dagger.

He drops it into the gray water. Watches it vanish.

RAVI (V.O.)
Six names. Six betrayals.

A pause.

RAVI (V.O.)
For the Code. For her.

A DRONE scans above. Its red light crosses his face and passes.

All the voices of the scene, Talarin, Alina, the guards, WHISPER BACKWARD over the final image.

Ravi walks into the haze. The city swallows him.

CUT TO BLACK:

TITLE CARD: SHATTERFALL

ONE DRUMBEAT. METAL IMPACT.

FADE OUT:

EXT. SLUM DISTRICT - PRE-DAWN

ASH drifts like spores through skeletal high-rises. The skyline hums, but down here, dead. Dead quiet.

Ravi moves through narrow alleys, a shadow among ghosts. Scarves hang from wires. Burned sigils on walls. Children sleep in barrel dens.

Whispers precede him. Doors lock. A dog whines, then silences itself. Ravi doesn't look up. Doesn't slow down.

He passes a makeshift mural, half-smeared with ash and blood. It once depicted young freedom fighters. A younger Ravi among them. Arms slung around ALINA. Another teen. A third blurred by fire damage.

Ravi stops. Touches the part where Alina's face was. The paint is cracked. Burnt.

ABOVE, A FRAYED BANNER FLAPS. Its symbol: a bleeding eye pierced by three thorns, an OLD REBEL CREST.

RAVI (V.O.)
What we lost, we buried. What we buried, we became.

He moves on.

EXT. SLUM COURTYARD - MOMENTS LATER

A tensioned square of concrete and blood-stained tarps. Locals pretend not to watch. An OLD WOMAN peels potatoes in rhythm, eyes never lift.

Ravi passes a GANG SYMBOL tagged low on the wall. a blade wrapped in wire, partially crossed out with a red smear. It triggers something in him.

He touches his side, where a scar runs beneath the layers. Then keeps moving.

Around the corner, a CHILD (9) follows at a distance. Dirty hoodie. Wide eyes. Curious but afraid. The kid steps where Ravi stepped.

Ravi disappears around a wall.

The child rounds the corner, empty. Ravi's gone. Nothing.

INT. ALINA SHRINE ALCOVE - DAWN

A tight, ash-colored nook. Walls etched with coded carvings. An altar built from scrap. A faded scarf, hers.

Ravi kneels. Bows his head.

He lights a small flame. Smoke curls into the shape of the Ash Covenant's sigil, then warps.

He leaves a single item: a MIRROR SHARD.

Behind him, a small figurine, handmade from wire and bone, catches light. Etched into its side, a name: MAEL.

RAVI (V.O.)
Memory isn’t enough. It must be carried.

INT. SLUM BOUNDARY CHECKPOINT - MORNING

A concrete outpost of rusted bars and molded barricades. Three ENFORCERS, unarmored, brutal, lean against an oil barrel fire.

ENFORCER 1
Who let the echo in?

ENFORCER 2
You smell that? War ghost stinks of rot.

Ravi walks straight through the checkpoint.

ENFORCER 3
(to Ravi)
Hold up. Where’s your sanction tag?

Ravi stops.

He turns. Silent. Just looks.

ENFORCER 1 steps forward, smirking. Grabs Ravi’s shoulder.

ENFORCER 1
You want back in, you pay. That’s how it works.

Ravi’s stare doesn’t break. A long beat.

He twists Enforcer 1’s wrist until it POPS.

ENFORCER 1 (CONT’D)
AHH—!

He falls, screaming. The other two draw batons, hesitate.

Ravi lifts his shirt, revealing the old CODE SCARS, ritual burns forming a shattered symbol across his ribs.

It’s a relic. Forbidden. But real.

The Enforcers back off. One SPITS.

ENFORCER 2
Ash rot’s walkin’. Let it pass.

Ravi walks. Not a word. Past them. Through ash. Into home.

CUT TO:

INT. MARKET QUARTER - MOMENTS LATER

Smoke. Vendors. Children. Crows.

The CHILD from earlier stands on a rooftop, watching Ravi vanish into the maze.

Their small hand draws a symbol in soot.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. SLUM DISTRICT - DUSK

A blood-orange haze bleeds through smog and ash.

Ravi moves through the low sprawl. Silent. Watchful.

He passes a MURAL, defaced, showing a Covenant officer in full regalia. A noose has been painted around the neck.

Kids play soccer with a severed drone casing. They freeze when they see him. One whispers.

KID
Ghostblade.

INT. ABANDONED ROOM - DUSK

Ravi stands in a gutted tenement. Peeling walls. Rotting mat. Faint markings on the ground. A child's height chart scratched in ash.

He kneels.

From beneath loose floorboards, he lifts a wrapped bundle. Oilcloth, stiff with age. Inside: a hand-drawn MAP of the district, a faded PHOTO of Alina, and a rusted medallion. The Code, fractured.

He pockets the photo. Stares at the map.

A red mark is circled.

CLOSE ON. The map’s edge, where in tiny script, someone’s written: SHE WAITS IN FIRE.

EXT. DISTRICT STREETS - NIGHTFALL

Crowds swell. Lights sputter to life, jury-rigged LEDs strung between stalls. Drums echo somewhere deep. Dogs bark. A baby cries.

The air thickens.

Ravi pulls up his hood.

EXT. NIGHT MARKET - DISTRICT EDGE - LATER

Dense. Alive. The scent of fried fat, blood, and rot. Neon flickers through ash rain. Cracked stalls. Plastic tarps. Everyone armed or watching.

A dozen satellite speakers BLARE distorted Covenant propaganda.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
Order is freedom. Obedience is peace.

COVENANT ENFORCERS patrol in pairs. Gas masks. Steel batons. Shotguns slung. Slum citizens pretend not to see them.

Ravi moves through the crowd. Hood up. Blade tucked spine-side. Shoulders tight. A ghost in the living.

He follows a MAN, mid-40s, limping, arm inked with the same ASH SIGIL seen at Alina's death site.

The target moves through a butcher stall. Ravi shadows close.

INT. SLAUGHTER STALL - CONTINUOUS

Meat hangs on rust hooks. Flies buzz. A RADIO plays a warped war hymn.

Ravi closes the distance. Quiet. Surgical.

He SLAMS the target into the wall, hand over mouth, dagger to throat.

RAVI
Name.

TARGET
(gasping)
I just— I trade livestock. I don't—

RAVI
Your arm. The mark.

The man chokes. Ravi rips the sleeve. It’s NOT the Covenant brand. It’s a CHILD’S DRAWING. Misread in darkness.

A BEAT.

Behind him, a GIRL (11), watches. Frozen. No sound.

The target whimpers. Ravi looks at the girl. Looks at the blade. The hand trembles.

He steps back. Vanishes into the alley, shadow swallowing shadow.

EXT. ALLEYWAY - CONTINUOUS

Ravi walks fast. Ash thickens. He kneels behind a dumpster.

Shakes. Not from fear. From rage.

He unwraps the cloth around his blade. ALINA’S SCARF, still stained.

He wraps it tighter around the hilt. A vow redrawn.

RAVI (V.O.)
Never again unclear.

CUT TO:

INT. MARKET STALL - SAME TIME

The little girl still stands. Chickens chirp. The vendor calls to her. She doesn’t respond.

We HOLD on her face, until a speaker above her BLOWS OUT with static:

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
(distorted)
Fugitive identified.

INT. ASH COVENANT BUNKER - MONITOR ROOM - SAME TIME

A surveillance screen flickers, Ravi’s blurred silhouette frozen mid-stride.

Technicians adjust knobs. A FIGURE watches, silent, face unseen. Data scrubs across monitors.

TECH
Target matched. Updating the ledger.

We PUSH IN on the image, Ravi's form drowned in static.

The FIGURE'S silhouette catches the light just enough to show something off, a gleam of a prosthetic hand, mechanical fingers twitching. The voice modulator hanging from the neck pulses, low and inhuman. No face. Just presence.

CUT TO:

EXT. MEAT STALL ALLEYWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Ravi sprints through hanging tarps and rusted scaffolds. Shouts echo behind him.

ENFORCER (O.S.)
There! Move!

Boots SLAM the mud. A STUN BATON sparks. Misses his back by inches.

Ravi dives, shoulder-first, through a plastic divider. CRASHES into a rack of butcher hooks.

A jagged iron hook TEARS across his ribs. Blood blooms through his shirt.

He grits. Doesn't scream.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

Narrow. Rotting pipes. Trash water pools ankle deep.

Ravi limps now. Hides behind a freezer shell.

Distant voices fade. No footsteps.

He peels his shirt. Blood-soaked. The cut is deep, not mortal.

He wraps it with the scarf. Tight. Fast. Dirty.

A pause. Silence.

He breathes. Looks at the blood on his hands.

Moves.

EXT. SHADOW DISTRICT - BACK ENTRY - NIGHT

Ravi slips past a shutter. Faint sigils carved in the concrete mark the way.

He disappears into the narrow dark.

CUT TO:

INT. MIRA'S CLINIC - UNDERCITY - NIGHT

A rusted steel door SLAMS. Heavy latches BOLT.

Ravi stumbles in, bleeding. Drenched in sweat and blood. The gash on his side worse than we've seen. Not clean. Torn. Dug in.

MIRA SERIS (30s), fire-eyed, needle in teeth, already moving. Not warm. Not cold. Just precise. Surgical.

The place is sacred, not sterile. Candles line a cracked altar of tools. Shelves of salvaged meds. Sigils painted in bone-white ash across the walls.

MIRA
(on instinct)
Table. Now.

He drops his coat, winces as he climbs on. Shirtless. Scars like maps. Blood pools beneath him. One scar, older than the others, carved in looping geometry. Not memory. Oath.

Mira sterilizes forceps in flame. Glances at him.

MIRA (CONT'D)
Still can't tell if you're numb or just stupid.

RAVI
Either way, I bleed the same.

CLINK. Forceps dig in. She extracts a jagged shard of shrapnel. Drops it in a tin tray.

MIRA
You said never come back.

RAVI
Didn't plan to.

She dabs alcohol. He flinches, barely.

MIRA
And yet… the ash brings every ghost home.

She pulls a medallion from her neck. A flattened bullet etched with a faded sigil. She compares it to the BURN BRAND on Ravi's side.

MIRA (CONT'D)
You found one.

RAVI
Not the right one.

MIRA
Does it matter? Or is this just penance in pieces?

She leans in slightly, eyes narrowing.

MIRA (CONT'D)
That scar there, looped spiral, sun-burst center. That's a Seer's Mark. They were forbidden even before the Covenant fell.

Ravi says nothing. But something tightens in his posture, acknowledgment without admission.

Silence cuts sharper than steel.

MIRA (CONT'D)
Alina screamed for you.

That lands. The flinch this time is real.

RAVI
Where.

She steps back. Crosses to the wall. Pulls a cloth, reveals a grainy, blood-smeared PHOTO. A woman's body, symbols scorched into skin.

MIRA
Sector Ten. Checkpoint. They used her. Sent a message.

RAVI
(quiet)
Yeah.

He reaches for the photo, doesn't touch it.

MIRA (LOW, CUTTING)
She called for you, Razor. Said she found something under Sector Ten — an old symbol, burning through the new ones.
(beat)
You were two hours away.

RAVI
There was a lead. One of the Six.

MIRA
And she waited. For you. For mercy.
(a whisper)
When the checkpoint burned, she stayed behind. For the ones you left.

She sets the photo down. Watches him wrap his blade again, tight, with Alina's scarf. A vow redrawn.

This time, it isn't just memory. It's intent. The scarf is no longer a relic. It's a tether. A trigger.

MIRA (CONT'D)
So the Razor resurfaces.

RAVI
Only to cut clean.

MIRA
(smirks)
Kids call you Ghostblade now. Say you hunt nightmares.

RAVI
Then they haven't seen mine.

She opens a tattered binder. Pages of hand-drawn SIGILS. Some match the photo.

MIRA
These showed up after Alina died. Some we've never seen. Root Sign, maybe older. Pre-Covenant.

He flips a page. One SIGIL stops him cold, he's seen it. Butcher's stall.

FLASH CUT —

ALINA'S HAND. Charred. Fingers curled around a STONE PENDANT.

BACK TO SCENE —

Ravi’s jaw tightens. Mira watches him.

MIRA (CONT’D)
She wore that pendant every time she pulled someone out of the fire. Said it reminded her why.

Beat. He doesn’t look up.

MIRA (CONT’D)
You’re not the only one who lost her.

RAVI
I know.

She weighs his blade in her hand. Then sets it down. A boundary drawn.

MIRA
You don’t get to kill for both of us.

RAVI
I didn’t ask to be their myth.

MIRA
Didn’t stop them either.

Beat. Outside, a distant SIREN. Dogs bark. Then quiet.

MIRA (CONT’D)
(quietly)
Whatever you’re chasing… be sure it doesn’t become you.

He stands. Winces. Pulls on his coat.

RAVI
Steel remembers.

He exits. The door swings shut, revealing a CHILD’S DRAWING tacked behind it. A cloaked hero. Blade raised.

Scrawled into the steel: GHOSTBLADE LIVES.

CUT TO:

EXT. RUINED MONASTERY ACCESS TUNNEL — NIGHT

A rusted bulkhead door, half-sunken into soil. Vines choke the signage.

A symbol has been slashed out in red Covenant paint, old rebel mark defaced. Next to it, a child's sigil, re-drawn in ash, fresh.

RAVI (O.S.)
They tried to bury it.

INT. RITUAL CHAMBER — CONTINUOUS

A heavy iron hatch CREAKS open. Dust blooms.

Ravi steps into darkness.

His breath clouds in the cold. The space is vast. Carved stone and fractured mosaic, partially collapsed. Rain drips through cracks above. Crumbled steps. Water pooled in the edges. This was once a cleansing chamber, an oath vault, now forgotten.

Charred graffiti scars the walls. Some slashed. Some repainted. Others layered with Covenant propaganda, truth overwritten, rebellion erased.

Beneath the propaganda, older markings shimmer, pre-Covenant script, almost luminous under soot. A language that seems to shift if stared at too long.

Ravi's boots crunch over broken glass and old bone, childhood remains, long undisturbed. A small altar forms the center. Engine plating fused with bloodstained stone. Ritual reborn in wreckage. War memory made sacred.

Smoke curls through broken pillars. Candles flicker in spirals, a forgotten formation. At the center: a STONE SLAB. Charred, cracked, soaked in old rites. Burnt offerings. Ash-dusted bowls.

Ravi kneels shirtless. His bandaged side still weeps, but he doesn't flinch.

A STEEL PLATE rests before him. Blank. Cold. Ritual tools: an AWL, a blackened blade, a dish of blood.

His fingers smear ash across the slab in a spiral. Not art. Pattern. Code. He dips the AWL into blood.

CLOSE ON — THE PLATE

The first stroke carves deep. The name bleeds. Each line calls one of the Six. Debts older than his war, names whispered when the Covenant was still ash.

FLASH IMAGE — A wall scorched in sigils. Children cry behind it.

Second name. Steel sings. FLASH IMAGE — Masked men holding a body underwater. A candle sputters out.

Third. FLASH IMAGE — A hand gripping Alina's pendant. Torn.

Ravi's breath falters. His eyes close. Just for a second.

Fourth. Fifth. Each name deliberate — a vow in blood.

He reaches the sixth. Hesitates. His hand shakes. Not fear. Memory. This name… slower. More pressure in the stroke.

FLASH IMAGE — A shadowed face. Familiar. A smirk. Then blood.

Her words return, ghost-slow, "Be sure it doesn't become you." The echo burns colder than steel.

Ravi finishes the carve.

He lifts the blade. BRANDS the plate's edge with a heated seal.

A whisper ghosts through the ruin, ALINA'S.

ALINA (V.O.)
Don't lose the part that bled for others.

He unrolls a strip of cloth, folds in a small item: A single bead, from Alina's pendant. He places it on the slab. Pours ash over it, mixing memory and vow. Then sears the plate shut over it. Fusing pain to purpose.

He lifts the finished plate. Still glowing. Still burning. Presses it to his forearm.

His skin smokes.

He breathes through it. Not stoic, steady. A rite completed. His scar hisses under the brand, old pain swallowing the new.

The ritual is done.

He dresses slowly. Re-wraps his blade. The cloth nearly dust now. One edge stitched with a small, faded sigil, the first one Alina ever carved.

A low wind howls from the tunnel. Distant, but real. He tenses. Not fear. Recognition.

RAVI (V.O.)
They don’t guard this place.

He stands.

RAVI (V.O.)
They fear what it wakes.

His shadow falls across the kill plate. Six names glowing faint in candlelight. A pattern older than even he knows.

We now see faint traces of older footsteps leading out another collapsed side tunnel, long-abandoned, maybe once part of the original rebel route grid.

A beat of silence. He extinguishes each candle with his fingers. One by one.

Darkness claims the space.

FLASH GLITCH
MEMORY:

Alina’s VOICE. Static. Distant. Familiar.

ALINA (V.O.)
Ravi… I need your help. It’s deeper than we thought. I think I found where it starts—

A pulse hums from the ash itself, blue and spectral, technology buried in faith.

INTERFACE SCREEN: Encrypted COMM feed. Time-stamped: ONE WEEK AGO. Unopened.

BACK TO:

Ravi stands in silence. Shame, rage, purpose converging.

He leaves the ruin without looking back.

The ash drifts in spirals behind him, forming, then erasing, the sigil of the Seer’s Mark.

CUT TO:

INT. SURVEILLANCE NODE 9 — UNDERCITY GRID — NIGHT

Cold light bleeds from flickering monitors. Rows of faces. Names. Maps. Techs operate in practiced silence, eyes hollow.

A MATCH ALERT blares.

SCREEN: Image freeze. RAVI, profile half-obscured in shadow.

TECH 1 (LOW)
Got a match. Sector Ten. Sigil trace confirmed.

TECH 2
No movement tag. He’s off-pattern. This is fresh.

The system begins to HUM, but then: A red symbol pulses across every screen.

TECH 1
What the hell is—

A lockout activates. Keyboards go dead.

TECH 3
(whispers)
Red Directive...

No one speaks. One junior tech glances over, fear in her eyes.

TECH 2
That’s not us. Someone else is—

The surveillance feed reboots.

A NEW ANGLE: a secondary monitor switches to a DIFFERENT ROOM. Smoke-glassed. Shadow-drenched.

The FIGURE from earlier, stands still, almost statuesque. Their face obscured by a sheer veil of light. The silence they command is absolute.

The only movement, their hand. A single sigil is tapped into their palm.

Instantly, Ravi’s feed vanishes.

CLOSE ON: One tech’s trembling hands.

A file opens by itself:

FILE: SITE 0-9

SUBJECT: RAZOR

CASUALTIES: 87

THREAT RANK: LEGEND - SIGIL ACTIVE

The entire room stills. Like prey. Like myth just became real.

TECH 1
He shouldn’t be alive.

Suddenly, a GLITCH —

On one monitor, Ravi stares upward. Just one frame. Unmoving. Unblinking.

TECH 3
...Did he see us?

TECH 2
Can’t. It’s one-way.

But no one breathes.

The system begins to scrub. Metadata gone. No trace. Erased in real-time.

The shadowed figure watches. Silent.

A holographic seal glows briefly across their palm: SEER’S MARK. Illegal. Ancient.

In the corner, a single LIGHT turns from green to RED.

The HUNT is live.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNDERCITY STAIRWELL — NIGHT

Ravi stands in shadow. The city below hums with curfew tension. He unwraps his blade slowly, fingers hesitate on the hilt.

A faint chime echoes in the distance. Metal on metal, soft, musical.

He closes his eyes.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. TENEMENT ROOFTOP — SUNSET — YEARS AGO

A thin slab of corrugated metal under pink-gold sky. Clouds stretch like smoke trails. The world feels distant from up here, like it hasn't turned to fire yet.

Young RAVI (10), ALINA (13), and SAHARA (12) sit in a loose triangle. Torn clothes. Bare feet. Grimy fingernails. But free.

Ravi works a shard of glass across a piece of scrap wood. Focused. Carving something we can't see yet.

SAHARA
Careful, Razor. You'll whittle your fingers off.

RAVI
Then I'll use teeth.

SAHARA
(grins)
Spoken like a hero.

ALINA
Or a lunatic.

They all LAUGH, loud, real. Unburdened by the world below.

Alina leans over. Drops a SMALL BLADE into Ravi's lap. The handle is bone, wrapped in red thread. Handmade. Sacred.

ALINA (CONT'D)
(soft)
Not for blood. For memory.

Ravi looks at it. Stunned. Doesn't know what to say.

ALINA (CONT'D)
If you're going to carry something, let it matter.

He nods. Tucks the blade away like it weighs more than gold.

Sahara slides closer. Flicks a pebble at Alina.

SAHARA
What about me? No shiny relic of honor?

ALINA
(smirking)
You've got that mouth. Sharp enough.

They tussle. Lighthearted. A moment that belongs to before.

Ravi watches them. Something in his eyes. Not quite jealousy. Not quite longing. Just alone.

The carving's done. He flips the wood scrap, it's a sigil. One we'll recognize later.

SAHARA
You're going to forget we were ever real, Ghostboy.

RAVI
Not if you keep talking.

SAHARA
(grinning)
I mean it. One day you'll climb so high you'll stop looking back.

She digs into her pocket. Hands him a tiny smooth stone. It's painted, a red mark on one side. Unfinished.

SAHARA (CONT'D)
It's not done yet. Finish it when you know who you are.

He takes it. Doesn't know what to say. Alina watches them both, her smile softer now.

RAVI
What if I forget?

SAHARA
(softly)
Then make them remember.

ALINA (O.S.)
Someday, the fire'll come for us.

SAHARA (O.S.)
Let it. We'll burn louder.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. CITY SKYLINE – NIGHT – NOW

Same rooftop. Same angle. But it's empty.

Rain. Ashfall. Distant screams.

The carving, now aged and cracked, still lies embedded in the rooftop.

We PUSH IN.

A smear of dried blood crosses the sigil.

A tiny painted stone rests beside it now. Finished.

RAVI (V.O.)
Every mark starts as memory.
The next one ends in blood.

CUT TO:

EXT. SLAUGHTERHOUSE DOJO - NIGHT

Blood-soaked tile. Fluorescent tubes buzz and flicker. A circular space, ritualistic in geometry, butcher hooks dangle overhead like iron teeth. In the center: a square marked in ash, faint embers still glowing at its corners.

Ravi steps inside. Alone. Blade drawn.

Across from him, a KNIFE MONK kneels. Emaciated. Head shaved. Arms crosshatched with scar-patterns. His robes hang in ritual folds, black and red. An aura of stillness surrounds him.

The Monk draws a blade. Not ceremonially, devoutly. Ancient steel. Oiled and revered.

With a slow breath, he SLASHES his own palm. Blood spatters the floor.

He presses the bleeding palm to his face. Smears a symbol. A half-sun over a vertical line, down his cheek.

Then, in ancient dialect.

KNIFE MONK
Ash to marrow. Blade to bone. May this cut sanctify.

The Monk lifts his head. A whisper on his breath.

KNIFE MONK (CONT'D)
Begin.

Ravi attacks. No hesitation.

STEEL ON STEEL. A flurry of precise, whisper-fast strikes. Both move like memory incarnate, as if this fight was carved into them before they were born.

The Monk pivots, elbows Ravi, then flicks a CUT across Ravi's arm.

Ravi flinches.

FLASH: A SLIVER OF MEMORY —

YOUNG RAVI. Bound to a wooden pole. A WAR PRIEST cuts the same line across his arm. Blood wells.

VOICES chanting, DISTORTED.

WAR PRIEST (V.O.)
If you feel pain, you haven't drowned it deep enough.

BACK TO SCENE —

The same look in Ravi's eyes. Not pain, FURY. But controlled.

They fight again. Faster. Messier. Blades CLANG against steel meat rails as the battle spreads.

The Monk GRABS a swinging hook overhead, uses it to vault, spinning midair.

Ravi DODGES, blade skimming the Monk's robe, slicing fabric.

They slam into a BLOOD TRENCH beneath the dojo, ankle-deep runoff from past kills.

Their footing slips. Grimy, splashing, savage.

Ravi headbutts. The Monk stumbles. Ravi SLAMS his blade into the Monk's leg.

The Monk screams, not in pain, but RITUAL ECSTASY.

KNIFE MONK
You've remembered...

Ravi SILENCES him. A final cut, smooth, through the neck.

The Monk crumples. Eyes open, dead.

Ravi breathes. Shaking. Hands twitch with adrenaline.

He kneels.

Takes a vial from his belt. Pours OIL onto the Monk's blade and palm.

STRIKES a match. Lights it.

The fire is silent. A sacred burn. No dialogue. No score.

Ravi watches until there’s nothing left.

CLOSE ON: The ash sigil at the center. The half-sun now glowing faintly, as if the ritual lit something deeper.

He presses two fingers to the blood trench. Paints a matching sigil on his own chest.

RAVI (V.O.)
To pass the threshold... one must burn what they once were.

CUT TO:

EXT. DOWNTOWN SLUMS - NIGHT

Rain needles the crumbling city.

LOUDSPEAKERS groan to life. Warped, analog, mounted like rusted parasites on lamp poles and archways. Their voices crackle.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
Citizens. He is not your savior. He is not myth. He is Razor.

CLOSE ON: a crooked CRT monitor bolted to a rusted scaffold. Footage flickers: RAVI, mid-kill. Grainy. Warped. Surveillance footage distorted by analog decay.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
A murderer. A terrorist. A relic of revolt.

The screen buzzes with static, flips to:

— Footage of a burning checkpoint.

— Corpses in a rain-slicked alley.

— Children screaming, dragging limbs.

A final chilling shot: RAVI, blood-spattered, kneeling over a body. A child's hand in frame. The footage slows. Then stops. Burned in like a myth.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
The Ghostblade bleeds your streets. He poisons your hope.

A faint mechanical WHIR... then a final line, eerie in its cadence.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
Order is loyalty. Loyalty is survival.

INT. STORM DRAIN - NIGHT

Mira crouches behind a corrugated pipe. Her face half-lit by the pulsing glow of the monitor outside.

She watches. Frozen.

She flinches, not from fear of him. From the accuracy of what’s coming.

In the distance, a MAN and his DAUGHTER rush past the screen. The girl stops. Stares.

GIRL
Is that... him?

MAN
Don’t look. Keep walking.

They disappear. The monitor BUZZES out.

Outside, tension has changed. Whispers sharpen to paranoia.

PASSERBY (O.S.)
Razor’s here.

PASSERBY 2 (O.S.)
He’s killing again.

PASSERBY 3 (O.S.)
What if they come for us?

A curfew klaxon wails in the background, shrill, oppressive. People scatter. A fight breaks out in an alley nearby, too fast to understand, too brutal to ignore. Someone screams.

On a cracked wall near Mira, graffiti once bearing a hopeful sigil has been overwritten: the blade mark crossed out in red.

INT. STORM DRAIN - CONTINUOUS

Mira pulls her cloak tighter. Trembling.

She looks down the photo of ALINA still clutched in her hand. Her thumb rubs the corner where Ravi once was.

Mira's eyes flick upward. Not fear. Not certainty. A fracture of both.

MIRA (SOFT)
Please... don't make me doubt you.

The static dies.

Rain falls harder.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED TRANSIT TUNNELS - NIGHT

A labyrinth of ruined concrete. Flooded rails. Tag-sigils carved into pillars like warnings. Faint torchlight flickers in the distance.

Ravi descends a crumbled staircase, blade sheathed but fingers twitching.

He moves like vapor. Precise. Silent. Every muscle ready.

Ahead, barely visible, the SMOKE SISTERS.

One kneels. Chalks a circle. Places a bone idol at its center.

The other strikes a match. Lets it burn to the fingers.

They inhale the smoke deep. Trance-like. Controlled.

SMOKE SISTER 1
No fire before the cut. No cut before the mark.

SMOKE SISTER 2
No mark without the breath.

The flame drops, extinguished in the soot.

The sisters step backward into the dark. Fade into shadow.

Ravi approaches, slow, alert, when: A whisper of motion.

SISTER 1 darts from the smoke, ghost-silent, blades curved like bone fangs.

Ravi deflects. JUST in time. Steel CLASHES in sparks.

SISTER 2 emerges behind him, synchronized. The two fight as one.

They strike in tandem. Twisting, breath-timed patterns. A living ritual.

Each attack flows like calligraphy.

Each parry a breaking of ancient rhythm.

Ravi absorbs. Adapts.

Counters, barely.

A blade skims his cheek. Blood beads. He grits his teeth.

Then, a misstep.

A pause in their breath cycle.

Ravi uses it.

Slides in, brutal and fast —

STEEL FLASH. SISTER 2 drops, throat opened, red blooming.

SISTER 1 freezes. Shock. Rage.

She lunges with a savage cry.

Ravi pivots, dodges, KNOCKS her mask off. She’s barely more than a girl.

She swings again, desperate now.

He pins her, blade poised.

But freezes.

She looks like someone.

Same eyes. Same terror. Same helpless defiance.

ALINA, long ago.

The blade trembles in Ravi’s grip.

RAVI
...go.

She stares, stunned.

RAVI (CONT’D)
Run.

She does. Vanishing into shadow.

Ravi exhales, gutted. A small mercy.

He leans against the wall. Breath sharp.

The SMOKE still hangs, faint in the air.

FLASH BLUR — a memory not fully his:

- A CHILD stumbles through blood-soaked corridors.

- A mask being pulled over a young girl's face.

- Alina? No, the girl becomes a Smoke Sister.

- A tower of bone. Sigils scorched into its base.

His hand jerks reflexively to his blade. Steady. Shaking it off.

INT. DEEPER IN THE TUNNELS - MINUTES LATER

Ravi walks alone. Echoes in every direction. He wipes the blood from his hands, more shaken than he wants to admit.

Suddenly — A sound.

His head snaps.

Something moved just ahead.

Ravi creeps forward.

Finds a SMALL SHRINE tucked in a dead-end alcove.

Candles melted down to wax puddles. A child's drawing nailed to the wall: A girl with a blade standing before a tower.

Underneath it:

WORDS carved in soot: "YOU CAN'T KILL MEMORY."

Below that, freshly scrawled: "EVEN SHADOWS BURN."

Ravi stares. Then turns. Back into the dark.

As he disappears into shadow —

FAINTLY, above ground. A low HOWL from distant loudspeakers.

A new broadcast tone.

COVENANT VOICE (V.O.)
(distorted)
All doors locked by dawn. Curfew Activated.

A mural on the tunnel wall, once depicting the Ghostblade in mythic strokes, has been defaced.

Painted over in red: RAZOR = DEATH.

Footsteps scatter above.

The city is shifting.

CUT TO:

EXT. SLUM TRENCHES - NIGHT

Heavy fog over rusted boxcars. Crows scatter. The ruined outskirts of the old city. Left to rot.

Wind howls low through broken train tracks, a place forgotten.

Ravi emerges from the tunnel access hatch, blood on his side.

Still reeling from the Smoke Sister fight. He moves slow, one hand pressed to his ribs.

He reaches a sagging fence. Leans. Catches his breath.

Behind him, silence. But something’s there.

He senses it. Turns.

MAEL VASK stands in the dark.

A girl, maybe seventeen. Wiry. Fire-eyed. Still. She didn’t sneak. She’s just there.

Mael steps forward. Quiet. Like him. Like shadow.

They stare at each other.

MAEL
You’re bleeding.

He says nothing.

MAEL (CONT’D)
Sit.

She doesn’t wait. Kneels. Opens a battered satchel.

Ravi doesn’t move.

MAEL (CONT’D)
If you drop in on people like that, maybe learn to dodge faster.

He almost smirks. But doesn’t.

She pulls out gauze. A shard of clean cloth. Alcohol.

Kneels. Unbuttons his shirt.

She works with speed and certainty. No hesitation. No flirt. No fear.

The wound is rough. A rib gash.

She wraps the bandage with a specific knot, tight, exact, the way Alina used to.

Ravi sees it. Feels it. Says nothing.

MAEL (CONT’D)
She tied everything like that. Bandages, satchels, shelter roofs. Said if it unravels, it was never real to begin with.

Beat.

MAEL (CONT’D)
You were at the underground clinic once, right? Before it burned.

RAVI
...You from the quarter?

MAEL
Born in it. Burned with it. Carried out by someone who didn’t stay.

That lands. He feels the sting.

MAEL (CONT’D)
I found this under the floorboards after they raided us.

She holds up a coin. Worn, with a hole punched through the center.

MAEL (CONT’D)
They said she gave these to anyone who couldn’t pay. Said it meant you still owed something.

Ravi’s breath catches.

RAVI
...That was mine.

MAEL
She never kept anything without reason.

Silence again.

Ravi looks at her. Really looks.

RAVI
You following me?

MAEL
Only if you’re going somewhere worth the blood.

She stands.

MAEL (CONT’D)
If you’re just here to bleed more streets, then you’re not her family. You’re just a shadow.

That one cuts. Hard.

Mael steps back. Tosses the coin. He catches it.

She turns. Starts walking into the smoke.

Ravi stands in place. Frozen.

The night howls again. A faint curfew siren in the distance.

He watches her disappear into the fog, like a spirit.

CUT TO:

EXT. MIRA'S SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

A slum-side corner. Cracked walls. Steam hissing from broken pipes. The only sign of life, faint light flickering behind a boarded window.

INT. SAFEHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Mira sets a kettle down. Her eyes flick to the door, she’s felt it too. The shift. The wrongness in the air.

She moves fast, not panic, muscle memory. Grabs a folded blade from under a sink tile. Locks the back door. Flips a switch on the floor. A metal brace slams across the main entrance.

She steps into the center of the space, a single bulb overhead. She waits.

A beat.

Then —

- GLASS SHATTERS.

- SMOKE pours through the side vent.

- A SCREAM, not hers.

TWO SHAPES breach through the back.

ASH COVENANT ENFORCERS.

Black rigs. Painted masks. One carries a sigil-branding rod, still hot. The other, wire and clamps.

Just behind them, in the shadows, a THIRD MASKED FIGURE.

SMOKE SISTER, the one Ravi spared.

She doesn’t speak. Doesn’t move. Just lingers.

Her hand trembles slightly. She looks away.

Slowly, she pulls her mask down tight.

She turns. Slips out. A shadow among shadows.

Mira doesn’t run.

She lunges, knife flashing, jamming it into the first ENFORCERS thigh. A spray of blood. He grunts, drops.

The second ENFORCER slams her into the wall.

A BONE CRACK.

She spits blood, laughs.

MIRA
You’re late.

They beat her. Stylized cuts, arms twisted, teeth broken, her scream swallowed into the hiss of steam.

They hold her down.

A rod drops into frame, searing red.

The branding rod hovers over her chest. Not rushed. Ceremonial. The operative begins to chant, fractured scripture in the Covenant dialect. The red tip SCREAMS as it sears flesh.

We catch a flash of the mark: a half-sun over a line, the inverse of the Knife Monk's.

Mira doesn't scream this time. Just exhales smoke and blood.

Her eyes burn through the mask. Pure defiance.

SMASH TO:

INT. SAFEHOUSE - MOMENTS LATER

The front door unbraced. Open.

Mael, soot-smeared, panting, bolts into the alley beyond.

She doesn't look back.

Behind her, the kettle still hisses.

A single drip of blood hits the floor. Steady. Metronomic.

CUT TO:

EXT. BAZAAR ALLEYWAY - NIGHT

Thick with shadow. Vendors long gone. Ash drifts in like fog.

A SICKLE-SHAPED MOON bleeds through stormclouds.

Ravi moves through the slums like a ghost, half-shadow, half-blade. On a hunt. His eyes locked forward. Target unknown.

Footsteps.

He STOPS. Hand on blade.

Behind him, a whisper of breath.

He whips around. Mael stands there. Dirt-smeared. Out of breath. Eyes wild.

MAEL
(panting)
You have to come. Now.

RAVI
Wrong time.

MAEL
It's Mira. The safehouse. They came looking.

A pause. Air ripped from Ravi's lungs.

MAEL (CONT'D)
I ran. I tried to stop it.

Ravi's already MOVING. Past her. No words. Pure velocity.

EXT. LOWER STREETS - NIGHT

Ravi runs. Hard. Past boarded stalls. Past silent eyes in windows.

Ash kicks up with every step.

A DEAD DOG lies in the gutter, fresh. Not scavenged yet. Time is folding in on itself.

EXT. UNDERPASS - NIGHT

Lanterns sway. Dying light. Ravi's shape cuts past, pure blur.

Children huddle in corners. Watching.

A makeshift sign on a pole: "SHELTER CLOSED." Scribbled over with blood-red: "NO REFUGE."

CUT TO:

EXT. SAFEHOUSE BLOCK - NIGHT

Smoke curls from somewhere out of view.

Ravi slows.

Turns a corner -

EXT. MIRA'S SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

Door blown off. Windows shattered. Someone tried to torch it, but the stone walls fought back.

The silence is loud.

Tea kettle blasts.

Ravi steps inside. Blade ready.

INT. SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

The clinic is wrecked.

Cots overturned. Gauze black with ash. Supplies scattered.

No bodies... yet.

A faint COUGH.

Ravi pivots -

INT. BACK ROOM - NIGHT

Mira slumped against the wall. Bleeding. Breathing shallow.

She's still alive, but barely.

Ravi drops to his knees.

RAVI
Mira-

She reaches a shaking hand to his face.

MIRA
You shouldn't have spared her.

Ravi can't speak. His chest caves in.

MIRA (CONT'D)
They weren't hunting me.
(beat)
They wanted you.

A beat of silence.

Her hand falls.

Ravi stays there. Still. Destroyed.

The kettle SCREAMS in the distance.

A FOOTSTEP behind him.

MAEL (O.S.)
Ravi-

He turns -

Mael stands in the doorway. Soot on her cheeks. Bleeding from a cut at her temple. She’s trying not to cry and failing.

She sees Mira.

Sees Ravi.

Her legs buckle. She sinks to her knees.

No words. Just grief.

Ravi moves to her, instinctive, and pulls her in.

They sit there, broken, the kettle shrieking behind them.

The burner light still glows. Unmoving. Time passes like weight.

Quick, stylized intercuts:

- Ash Covenant soldiers dragging masked children through flame.

- Branding rods laid out like relics.

- A mask forged in fire, cooled in blood.

- Mira once stitching a child's wound. Her hands steady. Her eyes fierce.

- The Smoke Sister who fled, alone in an alley, mask in her lap, weeping into her gloves.

CUT TO:

EXT. SAFEHOUSE ALLEY - EARLY MORNING

A slum-side corner. Cracked walls. Steam hissing from broken pipes. The black of night thinning to a dirty gray, a slow bleed across the sky.

Mael sits on a broken step. Knees pulled in. Eyes hollow. Not crying, that’s long gone. She’s shaking, barely holding her breath in.

Smoke still curls from the half-open door behind her. The kettle’s scream died hours ago. Only the steam whispers now.

Ravi steps out.

His silhouette framed by the broken doorway. Shirt stained, Mira’s blood, dried to black. A ghost in human skin.

He doesn’t look at Mael. Doesn’t speak.

Straps the blade to his back. Cemented. Something in him hardens.

He starts walking.

Mael turns, just enough to see him go. Her voice is barely breath, but it cuts.

MAEL
Make it count.

He doesn’t turn.

Just vanishes into fog.

CUT TO:

EXT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - EARLY MORNING

A brutal silhouette against a storm-laced sky. The clouds throb with pending violence. Dawn light breaks in fractured red. Ash falls like dry rain.

A long trail of fresh blood smears the concrete. Leading inward.

Ravi steps into frame. Fire and ruin, wrapped in skin.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - LOBBY - CONTINUOUS

No guards. No resistance. Just a GIRL, maybe ten, seated behind a shattered reception desk.

She lifts a cracked intercom handset.

GIRL
He’s here.

Click.

The elevator dings, soft, precise.

Ravi doesn’t wait.

He takes the stairs.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - FLOOR 1 - LEVEL CONFESSION

A corridor of repurposed confession booths. Now blood-stained torture pods.

Hooks. Shackles. Dried screams in the air. One booth still swings on rusted hinges.

A TEEN BOY guards the hallway, chest branded, blade in both hands. Eyes wide. Shaking.

Ravi sidesteps. Disarms. A quick crack, not fatal. The boy drops.

Another man lunges from the dark, eyes wired with zealotry.

Steel flashes. Ravi moves like a lit fuse.

One breath. One motion. One kill.

He pushes forward.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - FLOOR 2 - LEVEL JUDGMENT

Mock courtroom. Galleries of decaying bodies in judges’ robes. Their masks melted to bone.

A looping voice reverbs through hidden speakers:

JUDGE (V.O.)
All rise. Verdict rendered. Guilt assigned.

Two ENFORCERS burst from behind the pews.

Ravi meets them in kind.

One swings a gavel-spear. Ravi grabs the shaft, turns it — drives it through the attacker’s throat.

The other ENFORCER pins him —

Ravi SMASHES his skull against the bench edge. BONE CRACKS. Silence.

He limps forward. One arm red. Breathing harder now.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - FLOOR 3 - LEVEL PUNISHMENT

Steam-thick hell.

Industrial wheels churn. Bones dangle from chains. Slaves work the machines, barely alive.

Shock collars. One flinches. A switch clicks.

The wall rotates.

A GUARDIAN steps out, wielding a flame-thrower.

Ravi dives. Flame hisses across his back.

He grabs a steel tray. Hurls it.

It CLANGS off the Guardian’s tank —

BOOM. Fire rips through the floor.

Screams vanish into smoke.

Ravi walks through the flames, a silhouette of fury.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - FLOOR 4 - EXECUTION HALL

The EXECUTIONER waits.

Seven feet. Robe of iron. Hook-hand. Scripted skin.

Chains coil his torso. He steps forward, voice like a hammer.

EXECUTIONER
The sentence is death.

He charges -

Ravi barely dodges the first strike, the hook SHATTERS a pillar.

They fight. Dirty. Vicious. Close-range.

Ravi is thrown, through a glass sculpture. Blood everywhere.

The Executioner advances.

Ravi rises, slower now. Grim.

Another swing.

Ravi catches the hook, wraps it around his bleeding arm, drags the giant down.

RAVI
Judgment’s over.

He drives his blade up through the jaw, deep.

A final breath rattles.

Dead silence.

INT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - MOMENTS LATER

Ravi emerges. Burned skin. Shirt half-burned.

One hand bloodied, the other, still wrapped in chain.

The SIGIL, a cursed mark from the massacre, clearly visible now across his exposed chest

He doesn’t hide it.

EXT. EXECUTIONER'S TOWER - REAR EXIT - NIGHT

Steam curls around broken stone.

Ravi steps into the alley. One breath away from collapse.

Sirens in the far distance. But nothing here. No witnesses.

CLINK.

A metallic noise behind him.

He turns.

A small SOOT-STREAKED CHILD stands at the threshold. Eyes hidden under hair.

She tosses something — underhanded.

It skips. Slides across the stone.

TIK-TIK-TIK.

A LEATHER NECKLACE. A COIN with a hole through its center.

Ravi’s breath leaves him.

He drops to one knee. Hand trembling.

He picks it up, turns it in the ash-light.

It’s his. The coin Alina once gave him. The one Mael returned.

He looks up —

The child is gone.

Only steam and silence remain.

Ravi doesn’t move.

Not a word. Not a scream. Just weight.

His eyes wide. Wet. Alive.

Something inside him cracking wide open.

CUT TO:

EXT. SLUM PATHWAY - EARLY MORNING

Ash-fog over broken rooftops. The sky cracked open in bruised lavender. A rooster crows, distant, out of place.

Ravi, blood still drying on his hands, walks aimlessly.

The necklace - coin. Still in his palm.

Footsteps. Whispers. A strange stillness ahead.

He looks up —

AHEAD, a knot of ONLOOKERS, scattered in a loose semi-circle. No one speaks. No one moves.

At the center. A makeshift platform. Crude. Fast-built.

On it — Mael.

Tied to a post. Knees bruised. Neck cut. Leather strap biting skin. Her eyes, defiant. Face swollen. She’s been beaten.

But she’s alive.

Ravi doesn’t run. He walks. Fast.

The crowd starts parting, as if something massive passes among them.

ON THE PLATFORM

An ASH COVENANT SOLDIER stands beside her. Ornate mask. Burnished axe.

He looks up. Sees Ravi.

Doesn’t run. Doesn’t flinch.

He SLAMS the butt of the axe to the wood, once.

MAEL
(softly, to Ravi)
Make them remember.

Ravi freezes, too far to stop it. Too close to look away.

SNAP.

The axe drops.

A stylized CRACK — like wood splitting.

Blood sprays.

Mael’s body crumples.

Ravi — Breaks.

He drops to his knees.

The necklace still clutched.

Eyes empty. Mouth open — no sound comes.

Around him, the crowd is gone.

ASH COVENANT SOLDIERS begin to circle. Blades. Rifles. Slow, measured.

Their trap worked. Ravi doesn’t care.

He just stares at her body, eyes rimmed in red.

His breath ragged. His body ready.

EXT. NARROW ALLEYWAY - PRE-DAWN - CONTINUOUS

A sliver of dying night. Smoke-drenched. Trash drifting in puddles. Ravi stands, Mael’s necklace clenched in one blood-slicked fist.

His breath saws in and out.

From every shadow, ASH COVENANT SOLDIERS EMERGE. Blades. Bolts. Batons.

They fan out. Five. Then ten. Then more. Circle tightening.

Ravi doesn’t raise a weapon.

They rush. He reacts. PRIMAL.

- A jagged rebar rod tears from the wall — RAMMED into a soldier’s chest.

- Another charges — Ravi SIDE-STEPS, slams his head into rusted piping.

- A bat swings — Ravi CATCHES it, turns, CRACKS it across three skulls.

He’s getting sloppy. Slower. But more brutal.

A flash — he sees the AXE. The same one used on Mael. He grabs it.

Then — it becomes performance art. A massacre. Mythic.

- The axe arcs once — takes a leg.

- Again — takes a head.

- He spins into two more, splitting one clean across the spine.

But there are too many.

He stumbles. Bleeding from the ribs. A bolt in his thigh. Vision blurring.

They swarm.

RAVI
(hoarse, whisper)
Come on—

He lunges again, but collapses to one knee.

A gun cocks behind him.

Ravi closes his eyes—

And then —

SWISH. A blade whistles past. Drops the gunman.

SILENCE. Then— the GREY VULTURE enters frame. Just a silhouette at first. Moving with liquid death.

- A blade slides from his sleeve — CUTS a throat without stopping.

- Spinning kick. Two more down.

- He uses the falling body of one soldier as a SHIELD while unloading dual pistols — headshots. Fast. Precise.

Ravi stares — breathless. Eyes wide.

He turns, sees another figure moving in the smoke — SAHARA.

Striding through ash like a vision. Blood on her hands. Eyes locked on Ravi.

He's fading fast. Vision a smear. He sees her lips move, hears nothing but static.

She reaches him, just as his knees buckle.

Catches him. Lowers him down.

SAHARA (V.O.)
You're going to be okay.

He looks up at her, eyes glassy, searching.

RAVI
(small, broken)
She was just a kid.

SAHARA presses his wound.

SAHARA
So were you.

The sound drops out.

GREY VULTURE stalks through the last remnants of soldiers — not a word. Just clean, surgical violence.

Ravi's eyes flutter. Black closes in.

FAINT IMAGE: Mael's face. Then Alina's.

His hand opens as the necklace falls to the dirt.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED SHRINE - NIGHT

A forgotten place. Ruins grown over with rust ivy and sigil moss. Stone lions cracked at the jaw.

Ravi lies on a slab wrapped in old prayer cloth. Wounds tended, shirt torn open, chest heaving.

A ring of candles burns around him. Sahara and the Grey Vulture stand watch.

Beyond them, FOUR OTHER FIGURES. Cloaked. Masked. Watching. Ghosts of an older war.

SAHARA
(to Vulture)
He was ready to die.

GREY VULTURE
He still might.

A beat.

One of the figures steps forward. Female. Wounded eyes behind an iron veil.

IRON VEIL
When he wakes, it begins.

They nod to the sigil glowing faintly on Ravi's chest, just above the heart.

IRON VEIL (CONT'D)
No more running. No more mercy.
Not after this.

The candle flames shudder.

Ravi stirs.

His eyes open, but don't blink.

Like something else has returned in his place.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED SHRINE - MORNING GREY

The sky is raw silver. Wind scatters ash across broken statues, forgotten gods with hollow eyes.

Ravi lies against the cracked base of a fallen obelisk. Bandaged. Barely conscious. Every breath is work.

Sahara crouches nearby, grinding herbs in a stone bowl. Her movements are precise, ritualistic.

Near her: a smoldering cookfire. Clean cloth. A satchel of old war tools, repurposed for care.

She dips a strip of cloth into boiling water, wrings it out. Approaches him.

SAHARA
This is going to burn.

RAVI
What doesn't.

She presses the cloth to his side. He flinches, bites back a sound.

SAHARA
You were almost dead. Again.

RAVI
You keep pulling me out.

SAHARA
Don't make a habit of it.

She smears the paste on his wound. A black salve that sizzles. Ravi sucks in a breath. His hand grips the stone under him.

Sahara leans closer, the scent of her like soil and smoke. Her sleeve falls, revealing a cut on her shoulder.

RAVI (QUIET)
You're bleeding.

She shrugs. He sits up, slowly, painfully, and reaches for the salve.

She lets him.

He smears it on her wound. Their eyes don't meet.

A beat of silence.

FLASHBACK TO:

EXT. ROOFTOP - YEARS AGO - NIGHT

RAVI and SAHARA — teens, dirt-covered, wild-eyed, lie on a rooftop under a fractured moon.

Below, sirens ring out. Smoke rises.

YOUNG SAHARA (V.O.)
You remember that rooftop in Sector 9?

YOUNG RAVI (V.O.)
First time you disarmed a charge.

YOUNG SAHARA (V.O.)
First time you smiled.

Ravi holds up a coin, the same coin. Flips it.

YOUNG RAVI
Heads, we leave. Tails, we kiss.

She grins. Grabs the coin mid-air.

YOUNG SAHARA
Coward's move.

She almost kisses him.

But a BLAST below ends it. The moment gone.

BACK TO:

EXT. ABANDONED SHRINE - CONTINUOUS

SAHARA
You still have it?

She pulls the coin from her pocket and places the chain in his palm — Mael's necklace. Blood dried on the edge.

RAVI
She died with it.

SAHARA
She followed you.

Ravi nods.

A gust of wind moves through the shrine. Candles flicker. Ash swirls.

SAHARA (CONT'D)
This place was a temple. Before the fires.

RAVI
Now it's just bones.

SAHARA
Still sacred. Still standing.

He looks up. At the shattered dome above. Morning light cuts through, a single beam warming his face.

He closes his eyes.

RAVI
I can’t keep losing them.

SAHARA
Then don’t. Kill what kills them.

He looks at her. She’s not offering comfort. She’s offering clarity.

He slowly sits fully upright, still aching, but breathing deeper. Stronger.

As he adjusts, the cloth across his chest slips.

SAHARA’S EYES DROP — the sigil above his heart. Just visible beneath the edge of a bandage.

It pulses once, not light, but heat.

SAHARA (LOW) (CONT’D)
It’s getting stronger.

RAVI
It never stopped.

Beat.

SAHARA
You’re not going to stop, are you.

RAVI
Wasn’t planning to.

He smiles, just barely.

SAHARA
Next time — try not to die before I get there.

RAVI
Deal.

They sit in silence. Ash drifts. A moment of peace carved from the wreckage.

Sahara watches him as he leans his head back.

SAHARA
(soft, unsure if he hears)
I still wonder what would've happened if we flipped heads.

Ravi doesn’t respond. But his jaw tightens.

His fingers close tighter around the coin.

Something in him cracks. He leans forward, breath ragged.

RAVI (HOARSE)
Alina. Mira. Mael.

He can barely say their names. Like they cut coming out.

RAVI (CONT’D)
Every one of them... I was too late.

SAHARA
You survived. They followed you because they believed.

RAVI
Belief doesn’t bring them back.

A long pause.

RAVI (CONT’D)
I should’ve died in that fire.

Sahara doesn’t look away. Her voice barely a whisper.

SAHARA
You were made in it.

Beat.

SAHARA (CONT’D)
And you don’t get to give up.

He looks up at her. Eyes wet. Rage and guilt swirling in equal measure.

She reaches over. Places a hand on his.

SAHARA (CONT’D)
Let them be your reason. Not your grave.

He swallows hard. Nods, once.

Silence.

Then, faint in the distance, a WHISTLE. A signal. Time’s up.

Ravi rises. A little unsteady. But his eyes are clearer. The blood haze lifting.

He buckles his belt. Grabs his blade. Nods once.

SAHARA (CONT'D)
Sixty percent?

RAVI
Give or take.

SAHARA
Good enough.

They move to exit, but pause.

Something shifts in the wind.

SAHARA (CONT'D)
(under her breath)
They'll be watching.

RAVI
Who?

She doesn't answer.

They walk out of the shrine. Together. Toward what waits.

CUT TO:

EXT. WAR SHRINE RUINS - LATER

The fire's out. Ash cooled.

Ravi tightens a wrap on his ribs. Stiff. Determined.

Sahara checks a pouch, two vials left. One blade. No food.

A sound, soft, deliberate, BOOTS ON STONE.

From shadow: THE GREY VULTURE.

He doesn't speak. Just tosses a folded scrap of paper beside them. A target sketch. Coordinates. Blood-signed.

GREY VULTURE
You have one hour.

Gone. Just like that.

Sahara watches Ravi.

SAHARA
Can you move?

RAVI
Not far. Not fast.

SAHARA
That's enough.

CUT TO:

EXT. SECTOR 9 ROOFTOP LEDGE - SUNSET

The city sprawls below. Quiet. Distant. Wind hums through rebar and ruin.

Ravi sits where he once did as a boy. Same view. Older eyes.

Sahara stands behind him, guarded. Wounded. Still whole.

A long pause.

SAHARA
You're not ready.

RAVI
I don't have time to be.

SAHARA
There's always time to stop.

RAVI
Not for me.

She moves closer. Not touching.

SAHARA
What if I asked you to?

RAVI
Don't.

SAHARA
New name. New city. I have it lined up. Clean IDs. Route through the Zone.

RAVI
You've thought this through.

SAHARA
I've had years.

He looks at her. And we finally see it: His heartbreak isn't rage, it's love, stretched to breaking.

RAVI
I'd go. Right now. If I thought they'd leave you alone.

She flinches.

SAHARA
They don't know I'm alive.

RAVI
They will.

A gust cuts between them. Cold. Final.

He sets the coin on the ledge between them.

RAVI (CONT'D)
Heads, I walk. Tails, I run with you.

She stares at it.

SAHARA
That's not fair.

He flips it.

Catches it.

Doesn't look.

Pockets the coin.

RAVI
Goodbye, Sahara.

He turns. Walks.

SAHARA
I'd rather you hated me.

RAVI
That would be easier.

He disappears down the stairwell.

She stays. Alone. Eyes locked on where he vanished.

Her hand brushes the coin imprint in the dust. It's still warm.

Off her face, something lost, something broken.

CUT TO:

EXT. DERELICT SKYTRACK - DUSK

The horizon burns rust-orange. Wind whips through the skeletal remains of a collapsed monorail system. Twisted steel. Shattered pylons. A fading world on the edge of silence.

Ravi walks alone. Hood up. Shadow long behind him.

He moves like a man with no destination, only momentum.

His wounds are half-healed. His gait's stronger. But his eyes are worse. Deader. Like something inside was buried back at the shrine.

He passes a torn banner, an old Ash Covenant sigil flapping in the dusk breeze. He doesn't look at it.

A single bird call. High. Artificial.

Ravi stops.

Looks up.

Nothing.

SUDDENLY, the scrape of metal. Just behind him.

Ravi spins, blade already halfway drawn —

—but there's no one.

Until there is.

From shadow, THE GREY VULTURE steps forward. Calm. Crisp. Every inch of him wrapped in scavenged armor and high-tech remnants. Like a myth walking out of the industrial graveyard.

He doesn't raise a weapon.

GREY VULTURE
You were faster when I saw you last.

Ravi says nothing.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
Sector 6. Gas tower collapse. You carried three out.

RAVI
You bounty?

GREY VULTURE
If I were, you'd be bleeding.

RAVI
So what are you?

A pause.

GREY VULTURE
Curious.

He walks a slow circle around Ravi, inspecting him like a weapon being appraised.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
The coin. The girl. The warehouse burn. The temple strike.

RAVI
You watching me?

GREY VULTURE
Watching them. You're just... noisy.

Beat.

RAVI
Then say your piece. Or swing.

GREY VULTURE
Ash has a list. You're not at the top anymore.

That lands.

RAVI
Who is?

Vulture steps closer. Drops something. A data stick. Red casing. Singed at the edge.

GREY VULTURE
They're hunting the architects now. Myth chasers. Blood for relics.

RAVI
Why give this to me?

GREY VULTURE
Because someone tried to pay me to kill you. And I don't work for insects.

Ravi studies him.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
You're not the only myth still breathing, Ravi.

Beat.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
Just the loudest.

He turns.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
Do something quieter next.

He vanishes into the wind.

Ravi watches him go. Picks up the stick.

The light fades.

His eyes rise, west, toward the dead city skyline.

He pockets the drive.

Walks toward the dark.

A faint hum, distant, machine-born, rises in the silence. A signal, or a warning.

CUT TO:

EXT. ANCIENT CISTERN - NIGHT

Cold wind howls through the cracked, cavernous mouth of the dry cistern. A sky of black ash. The only light, a lantern staked in bone, its flame stuttering like breath.

RAVI stands shirtless at the edge. His back ragged from the last fight. Blood crusted into the grooves of old scars. Across his shoulder blades, the faint, faded tattoo of an old unit sigil, barely visible through scar tissue.

Across the pit, the VESSEL KEEPER. Masked. Wrapped in burnt orange cloth faded to rust. Motionless. A second blade now strapped to his back, ceremonial, untouched for years until tonight.

Between them, a ritual circle of ash, bones, and broken teeth. Symbols drawn in marrow. Glyphs scorched into the stone. This place was meant to remember, or erase.

RAVI
(quiet, to himself)
I don't even know what I'm trying to save anymore.

He steps forward, barefoot into the ash.

VESSEL KEEPER
Speak her name.

Ravi doesn't.

The Keeper kneels, draws a blade, hooked, ancient, still hot from the fire. Dips it in black oil. The oil smokes, carries the scent of burned copper and salt.

The Keeper whispers something into the ash. A name. The wind seems to stop.

He rises.

VESSEL KEEPER (CONT'D)
Begin.

The duel starts with stillness. Then—

AN EXPLOSION OF VIOLENCE.

Ravi lunges. Fast. Desperate. But the Keeper is pure economy. Every strike evaded by inches. Every counter precise.

Ravi eats a knee to the ribs. Another to the face. He hits the ground hard. Coughs blood.

But he gets up.

He swings high, feint. Low, connects. The Keeper staggers back, impressed.

Then the Keeper vanishes from sight, reappears behind him, HAMMERS the hilt into Ravi's spine.

RAVI
(through teeth)
Again.

They circle. Ravi's breath ragged. His left eye swelling. But his movements shift, less rage, more rhythm. Learned. Ancient footwork, forgotten in the world above.

VESSEL KEEPER
Good.

The Keeper slashes Ravi's shoulder, a spray of red.

Ravi twists the blade from his own flesh, uses the momentum to land a brutal elbow.

They collapse into the ash. Grappling. Grunting. Pure brutality now.

The Keeper pins him knife at throat.

RAVI
End it.

VESSEL KEEPER (CALM)
You misunderstand.

The Keeper flips him.

DRIVES the burning blade into Ravi's upper back, slowly, carving. Not to kill. To mark.

Ravi SCREAMS. Body seizing.

Visions strobe across his mind —

FLASHES:

- Alina holding a tiny wrapped bundle.

- A name whispered.

- A child that never came.

- A sigil—different than Ash. Forgotten.

- A room engulfed in blue fire. Not red.

Back to the cistern, Ravi writhes. The pain unbearable. But he doesn't fight it.

VESSEL KEEPER (CONT'D)
She gave you this name.

He whispers it. A sacred syllable. One we don't hear.

Ravi's body stills. The ash glows faintly around him.

VESSEL KEEPER (CONT'D)
You were never meant to die well.

A beat.

VESSEL KEEPER (CONT'D)
But perhaps... you were meant to change it.

The Keeper steps back.

Ravi breathes. Eyes wet. Looks down at his bloodstained hands.

RAVI (SOFT)
Her name...

His hand moves to the fresh wound. Fingers trace the branded symbol. Not as burden. But as oath.

Ash begins to swirl unnaturally — lifted by unseen force. Shapes almost forming.

Ravi stands. Taller. Straighter. Changed.

The Keeper is already walking into shadow. Dissolving into the black.

VESSEL KEEPER (O.S.)
(whisper)
Ashhound waits. Remember, she was forged in your fire.

Lantern dies.

Darkness.

CUT TO:

EXT. ASH PLAINS - DUSK

A blood-orange horizon. The wind low and strange. Ash doesn't drift, it coils. Like breath held.

Ravi walks, slower now. Every step heavy. His shoulders wrapped in soot-stained linen. The urn bound to his spine like a burden he refuses to put down.

He passes a CHARRED TOY, half-melted. The face of a doll burned off. Nearby, a mound of stones marked with blackened handprints.

A storm builds low in the distance, lightning without sound. Not natural. A gathering.

In the far distance, TINY FIGURES on the ridge. Watching. Waiting. Drawn to something old being reborn.

EXT. WAR-SCARRED MONOLITH - NIGHT

A cracked basalt slab, inscribed with THE ASH SCALE.

Five rings remain. Three crossed in blood. The fourth: SERA.

Ravi unsheathes his dagger. Doesn’t slash, just sets the blade to her name.

Blood beads. Soaks into the groove.

He breathes her name. Not out of hate. Not forgiveness either. Just fact.

RAVI (V.O.)
Ash remembers what fire won’t.

FLASH CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE EDGE - YEARS AGO - NIGHT

SERA, maskless. Not laughing. Not kind. Holding a girl’s arm too tight.

ALINA (20s) steps between them, younger, calm fury in her eyes. She says nothing. Just stares.

Sera lets the girl go. Ash falls like judgment.

BACK TO:

EXT. CRUSHED PASS - PRE-DAWN

The landscape fractures. War bones, helmets, shattered shrines. A REPEATER DRONE buzzes by overhead, ignoring Ravi.

Ahead, the edge of the ARENA. Dug into the earth like a wound that never healed.

CRESCENT TORCHES burn low in the ash. Runes smolder above the arch: TO ENTER IS TO BE KNOWN.

Ravi stops. Looks up at the flame.

Then steps inside.

The light fades.

Only heartbeat.

Only the ring.

CUT TO:

EXT. RED RING COLOSSEUM - NIGHT

Open sky. Floodlights flicker on towers of bent iron. Dust bleeds red underfoot, not from sand, but oxidized ash.

A crowd hums above. No cheers. Just hunger. The kind that remembers fire.

Two massive GATES creak open across from each other. One belches steam. The other... silence.

From the far gate, ASHHOUND SERA steps forward.

Armored in scavenged chrome and ironbone. Hair razored to the scalp on one side. Her EYES, burning gold. Not natural. Augmented. Chemical fury.

She drags a curved CHAIN AXE behind her, the teeth still wet. Metal sings against the stone.

Opposite her, from the smoke, Ravi.

No armor. Just ashwraps. Scarred chest marked with the still-healing burn from the Keeper’s blade. In his eyes. No anger. Just purpose.

An ANNOUNCER'S VOICE echoes over the PA system. Distorted, pre-recorded.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
(distorted)
Ashhound Sera. Six-time deathmatch victor. Killer of kin. Breaker of bloodlines.

Sera raises a fist. The crowd THUDS their boots. Dust lifts like breath.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
(distorted)
Challenger, Unknown. No name. No sponsors. No odds.

Ravi doesn’t move.

The HORN SOUNDS.

Sera charges.

Fast. Untelegraphed. Chain axe whipping up sparks. She’s chaos, full-body aggression.

Ravi ducks. Spins behind her. Elbow to spine. She grunts, but smiles.

SERA
Finally. A real one.

She twirls the axe, it SINGS through the air. Ravi evades, barely. She's faster than she looks.

They trade blows. No finesse. Just muscle and hate.

Sera kicks out Ravi's leg. He drops, rolls.

She leaps —

He catches her mid-air, redirects, SLAMS her into the ground. Dust explodes.

They both rise. Bleeding now. Circling. Predators cut from the same myth.

SERA (CONT'D)
You've killed more than me.

RAVI
That supposed to make me proud?

SERA
It makes you worthy.

She lunges again. But this time —

He sidesteps. Grabs her wrist, twists. Disarms the axe. It CLANGS across the arena.

Sera WHISTLES through blood. A SNAP.

From her bracer, a hidden BLADE ejects, slices Ravi's cheek open. He stumbles.

She knees him in the gut, HARD. He folds. She shoves him back, then rams her shoulder into his chest. He hits the dirt.

SERA (CONT'D)
Mercy is a wound you chose.

RAVI
(choking)
Alina chose it first.

Sera HESITATES, flicker of recognition.

Ravi grabs broken chain links, SWINGS. It wraps her ankle. He YANKS —

She falls. He surges forward —

She claws at his face, cuts across his brow.

Blood pours into his eye. He’s blind on one side. Wounded. Breathing iron.

Ravi flails, almost collapses. Grabs a handful of ash to his eye, stops the bleeding with fire grit.

Then — he charges.

TACKLES her to the ground. Pins her. Blade at her throat.

She spits blood into his face, laughs through it.

SERA
You don’t get to win this clean.

She twists her wrist, presses her hidden blade into his ribs. He jerks, pain radiates through his body. They both bleed out, breathing fire.

He tightens the blade at her throat. Every muscle trembling. She still smiles.

RAVI
End it.

SERA
No.

She shoves his blade deeper — into her own throat. Blood sprays across his face.

SERA (CONT’D)
I choose... my end.

But she doesn’t fall fast. She clutches his wrist, staring into him, unblinking. Blood bubbling between her teeth.

SERA (CONT’D)
You taught me this, how to make a death... mean something.

Her grip loosens. Her body folds forward, half-embrace, half-collapse. The world slows.

Ravi catches her. His blood and hers merge in the dust.

He can’t let go.

The crowd doesn’t cheer. Just silent.

Then, the BOOTS THUD again. A funeral rhythm.

Ravi rises, breath ragged. The weight of her body still clinging to his hands.

He looks down. Her blood has marked him, a smear across his chest forming the faint outline of a sigil.

A NEW SYMBOL glows under his feet, revealed by her blood. A call sign. A warning.

He looks up. Across the arena. A FACE watching from the shadows. GREY VULTURE. Still. Measuring.

Ravi stares back, hollow-eyed, barely standing.

RAVI
(under breath)
Let it come.

The lights shift. From blood-red to cold white.

Above the arena, a set of runes ignite across the colosseum wall, unknown script, ancient.

The crowd goes still.

One by one, they begin to kneel.

Not to Ravi.

To the symbol. The blood-born glyph that has awakened something older.

CUT TO:

INT. WATCHTOWER CHAMBER — SAME

The Grey Vulture watches Ravi through cracked glass. A figure behind him steps into the light — one of the Cloaked Elders from the Shrine.

ELDER
It has begun, then.

GREY VULTURE
It never stopped.

CUT TO:

EXT. ASH SANCTUM GATES - DUSK

Black stone cliffs rise like teeth. A jagged keep sits atop a war-scorched summit. The ASH SANCTUM. Gothic. Brutalist. Covered in bone banners and soot-stained relics.

Ravi limps up the final slope.

His ashwraps hang soaked in blood. Urn still slung tight. The echo of SERA'S FINAL WORDS still flickering in his mind — "I choose... my end."

Above, a lone VULTURE circles. Watching. Silent.

Wind howls between war-spiked spires. Metal banners CLANG. One bears the symbol of Alina’s old militia, slashed in half.

Another, more ancient, the glyph of the RED FOLD, thought extinct. Its edges burned. Forgotten.

Etched below it: “ASH NEVER KNEELS.”

INT. ASH SANCTUM - ENTRY HALL - MOMENTS LATER

The doors groan open.

Inside, a cathedral of war. Statues of past Ash Hands, faceless, broken. Blood-tech relics pulse on iron altars.

One relic: a serrated gauntlet inside ashglass, tagged: "THE FIRST VOW."

Each footstep echoes like thunder.

WHISPERS bleed from the walls. Ghost-echoes, not words. Echoes of WAR.

Ravi’s hand brushes the ash-slick wall.

A MEMORY bleeds in:

FLASH: A younger Ravi, laughing. Alina by his side. Fresh recruits. Hope.

BACK TO:

He closes his eyes. Breath ragged. Keeps walking.

INT. GAUNTLET PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS

A narrow hall flanked by steel obelisks.

Ravi enters. The first step TRIGGERS IT.

- A SPEAR lashes from the wall.

He DODGES. Barely.

- The second step: TRIPWIRE. He JUMPS.

- Third: a ceiling trap drops SCORCHED SAND, flaying skin.

He presses on. Bleeding. Limping harder now. Every movement a choice between pain or death.

INT. HALL OF FACES - MOMENTS LATER

Rows of cracked mirrors. Each reflects Ravi's younger self — idealistic, unsplit. No ash on his skin. Each one silently SCREAMS with accusation.

He stares into one too long. His reflection flickers — smiles. He smashes it with his fist. Bloodied knuckles.

A shard falls to the floor, revealing a carved phrase behind the mirror: "THE MASK NEVER BLEEDS."

INT. FINAL STAIRS - NIGHT

Ravi climbs slowly. Knees near collapse. Echoes of heartbeat now the only sound.

At the top, a BLAST DOOR carved with the old Ashblood creed: "Only through ruin do we see clearly."

From within, a faint, whispering code: "Ash never kneels."

Ravi lays his palm on it. It opens.

INT. WAR CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Smoke. Red light. Shadow.

At the far end, a THRONE of chainmail and bones.

Sitting on it, VANE. Calm. Waiting.

No words yet. Just silence. Tension. Past and future collapsing.

Ravi takes one step forward.

Then another.

A SYMBOL above the throne flares faintly: the SEVENTH SIGIL — a relic brand only invoked once every generation. It pulses like a wound reopening.

Vane stands.

VANE
The chamber asked for blood. Yours, not mine.

He lifts a black-metal talisman, the ASHBINDING CREST, and drives it into the center altar. The ground trembles.

Walls made of sootglass shimmer. Figures materialize in them: Ghost-echoes of past Ash Hands. Not just specters, but watchers.

WHISPERS
Not yet. Not yet.

Ravi watches them with hollow eyes. He steps into the duel circle marked by burned bones and scorched glyphs.

A vision flickers in the smoke, Alina. Not her body, just her voice, twisting from the relics.

ALINA (V.O.)
You were never meant to come this far.

The lights dim. The relic fires burn blue.

Vane moves first.

Fast. Controlled. He attacks low, a blade flash meant to cripple.

Ravi BLOCKS, barely. Then swings wide. They CLASH, hard enough to crack the bones underfoot.

Ravi counters — but Vane rolls through, grabs a nearby relic shard —

Throws it.

It EXPLODES mid-air. A DETONATING MEMORY RELIC. Shards burn through Ravi’s side.

He grunts, stumbles back, catches a chain hanging from the wall and SWINGS it into Vane’s neck.

VANE
Better. But you’re still holding back.

He presses a hidden plate on the floor —

Spikes shoot up in a circle around Ravi. A RELIC-SNARE.

Ravi's arm gets CAUGHT. Blood sprays. He yanks hard. BURNS through his own ashwrap to tear free.

More fighting. Close. Vicious. Less choreography, more desperation.

Vane shoves Ravi into a molten pillar. Ravi SCREAMS, skin sears. He uses the pain, spins, KNEES Vane in the gut, then HEADBUTTS him.

Vane staggers. Bleeding. Furious. But instead of attacking again —

He removes his own armor. Piece by piece. Drops it to the floor.

VANE (CONT'D)
Let the Sanctum see my blood.

He kneels. Arms wide. Exposed.

VANE (CONT'D)
I won't give you the death you gave Sera.

Ravi hesitates. But the voices, louder now. Echoing from the walls.

WHISPERS
One must fall. One must rise.

Vane pulls something from beneath his belt: a sealed ashflask.

VANE
Let the ashes choose.

He SMASHES it against his own chest.

Black powder ignites. Crawls like fire-veins up his throat. He convulses, burning from within.

Ravi moves to stop him, too late.

Vane locks eyes with him, body already breaking.

VANE (CONT'D)
Your name is written in the ruin now.

He collapses. Smoke rises from his mouth. Eyes turned to stone.

A moment of stillness.

SUDDENLY — the mural wall behind the throne shudders.

New glyphs BURN into its surface: RAVI. SEVENTH ASH HAND.

The floor below pulses red. A deep VOICE echoes from under the sanctum. Not Vane’s. Not Ravi’s.

Maybe Alina.

Or something older.

VOICE (V.O.)
Only through ruin do we rise.

CUT TO:

INT. WAR CHAMBER - MOMENTS LATER

Smoke coils lower now, almost pulsing. The shadows stretch, breathing.

Ravi stands frozen, breathing ragged. Vane's body cooling in the broken glyph circle.

The relic ash still floats in the air, but now it glows faintly blue.

As Ravi steps forward — A METALLIC CLICK.

A relic plate beneath his boot presses inward.

Tiny needles flash up, sting into his ankle.

Ravi winces. Too slow to dodge. The needles retract and a black fluid pulses through etched veins in the floor.

A WHISPERING HUM starts again. Louder now. Different.

WHISPERS (V.O.)
Trial Fog protocol confirmed.

His vision distorts, just a fraction. The chamber flickers. Details blur at the edges.

He coughs. Tastes copper.

His hand trembles slightly as he reaches toward the glowing wall, now oozing a thick, vaporous mist from the fractures.

The mist curls toward him, blue smoke with motes of ember light. He tries not to inhale but can’t help it.

FLASH:

A memory —

Alina, younger. Mask off. Eyes hollow.

ALINA (V.O.)
They said we were purging ghosts. What we were really burning was memory.

BACK TO:

Ravi wipes his nose. Blood.

His body shifts into combat readiness but his mind lags behind. Movements slightly delayed. His pupils blown.

He clutches the wall, the Trial Fog carving symbols into his awareness.

New glyphs reveal themselves beneath sootglass. Names he doesn’t know. His name.

The SEVENTH SIGIL pulses again, now burning directly on the chamber ceiling. As if watching.

He stumbles back toward the throne —

And VANE'S BODY IS GONE.

Ravi’s breath catches.

WHISPERS (V.O.)
You are not alone.

The chamber tilts, or maybe he does.

A mirrored shard falls from the ceiling, shows Ravi's reflection. But not as he is. As something older. Or newer. Hooded. Eyes branded.

RAVI
No... no.

His knees nearly give.

A familiar voice echoes, not Vane. Not Alina.

GREY VULTURE (V.O.)
What rises from fire must carry ash.

CUT TO:

INT. TRIAL CHAMBER - UNKNOWN TIME

Stone. Smoke. Shifting light.

A circular arena carved into living rock. No doors. No exits. Time feels unmoored, the blue glow of relic mist pulses like a heartbeat.

Ravi stands alone. Or seems to.

Then — movement. Across from him.

A FIGURE emerges from the fog. Robed. Hooded. It glides, not walks. Skin carved with glyphs. THE JUDGE OF ASH.

Ravi blinks hard. The fog claws at his mind. His blade is still in hand, though it flickers, as if caught between dimensions.

JUDGE OF ASH
(voice like rust and fire)
The Seventh has turned. But the turning must be tested.

WHISPERS rise from the walls, now voices. All the ones he's killed.

SERA (V.O.)
You spared me.

HOUND (V.O.)
You broke me.

VANE (V.O.)
You became me.

The Judge raises a hand and from the mist emerge SEVEN PHANTOMS. Not illusions. Not memory. Not fully alive either. Trial-forms. Ash-drenched reflections of each prior kill.

Each armed. Each ready.

Ravi steps into the center.

He tightens the bandage on his arm. Bleeding still. He nods once. Then attacks.

- The first phantom: ALINA. Young. Fierce. Fast. He dodges, but she cuts his cheek.

- The second: a BURNING MONK — his fists lit like brands.

They strike in tandem. Ravi takes hits. Gives worse. His rhythm stutters — the fog bites at his reflexes. He pushes through.

Clashing steel. Smears of blood. Bone on stone.

Ravi breaks the monk's neck. Rolls under Alina's blade and cuts her at the knees. The fog eats the phantoms as they fall — no time to rest.

More come. The twins he drowned. The tactician with iron lungs.

He takes them. Each fight harder. Each moment slower.

He falls once. Stands. Arm broken. Spits blood.

Only one remains.

The final phantom steps forward — It is Ravi.

Dressed in ashcloth. Hooded. With branded eyes, just like the shard vision.

RAVI
(breathless)
No.

The mirror-Ravi draws a blade of black flame.

They charge.

This is not a fight of skill, it's pure war.

Flesh tears. Masks break. Blade-locks and brutal knees. Ravi is losing. Then winning. Then losing again.

Blood coats the stones.

Finally, the real Ravi pins the phantom. Punches again. And again. And again. Screaming now.

The phantom bleeds ash and whispers.

PHANTOM RAVI
You are the beginning.

Ravi drives the blade in.

The Trial Chamber trembles.

Light erupts. Not warm. Not cold. Final.

The fog peels away. The phantoms vanish. The glyphs in the floor realign, into a NEW SYMBOL.

One never seen before.

Ravi lies on the floor. Breathing.

Alone.

CUT TO:

INT. LIMINAL GLYPH PASSAGE - BETWEEN TIME

Sound drops out.

All that remains: Ravi’s breath. The whisper of ash. The hiss of glyphs pulsing along sootglass walls.

He stands and stumbles forward.

Every step triggers a shift, a twitch of light, a flicker of memory, a pulse in his ankle where the needles struck. Ink-black veins coil upward beneath his skin, glowing faintly.

Glyphs underfoot form a path, barely visible, seared into sootstone like phantom scars.

He drops to one knee.

RAVI
(low)
Not yet. Not like this.

He breathes into the floor. Tries to still the convulsions in his hand.

A SYMBOL appears before him, not drawn, but burned into the air like hot glass cooling: THE BROKEN SCALE.

He reaches toward it. It vanishes.

Behind him, the whispers fade.

Ahead, silence. Then: a single CHIME. Low. Ritual.

The passage begins to slope upward. The smoke thins. Light shifts to a sickened gold.

Ravi pulls himself up. Limps forward. Every step steadier. Every breath closer to purpose.

His knife returns to his hand, as if summoned.

A final glyph flares on the wall beside him:

GLYPH TEXT: "WHAT IS CARRIED INTO FIRE DOES NOT RETURN THE SAME."

He steps through.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. FINAL DUEL CHAMBER - UNKNOWN TIME

Silence.

GREY VULTURE waits across the arena.

Ravi’s boots touch the sigil-cracked floor. His breath fogs in the cold.

They lock eyes.

The duel has not begun. But it’s already happening.

GREY VULTURE
You walk like a man. But you arrive like a weapon.

Ravi steps forward, blade tightening in his grip.

RAVI
I came to end this.

GREY VULTURE
Then begin.

Sudden SNAP, the glyphs ignite around Ravi in a spiral.

FLASH —

From the smoke: SERA. Eyes hollow, body marked by her death wounds. She doesn't attack — she MIRRORS his stance.

Then: THE ASHKEEPER — hovering, burnt mask, dripping wax-blood.

Then: VANE — half-broken, mouth stitched.

They stand around him. Silent. Echoes.

Each raises a blade in synch with Ravi.

Ravi lunges. The illusions DISSOLVE into light. Symbols explode across the floor. Each step burns.

WHISPERS (V.O.)
Kill enough ghosts... you become one.

The smoke clears. Grey Vulture has not moved.

GREY VULTURE
Alina made Vane to burn the future.
(beat)
She made you to carry it.

Ravi circles him slowly. We see his hands twitch — fading equilibrium. The TRIAL FOG still coursing.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
I was the whisper behind her scripture. The last rite no one speaks aloud.

He gestures, a wall slides open. A mural: SEVEN CHILDREN.

Ravi is one of them.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
You weren't born into this. You were carved.

RAVI
Then carve me again.

Ravi ROARS. Charges. Steel meets obsidian. Sparks ignite glyphs.

The floor SHIFTS, revealing pressure glyphs. One misstep, ash-blades rise from the ground.

They FIGHT through it. Every movement choreographed with symbolic weight.

Clashes echo like bells. One strike, a glyph flares red. Another, blue.

GREY VULTURE
This isn't combat. It's scripture.

Blood hits the stone. A sigil on Ravi's shoulder IGNITES, his own glyph.

He screams — but stands. Blade raised.

The ceiling groans. A compartment OPENS and a figure descends.

A CHILD. HOODED. Face burned. Holds an urn.

CHILD (V.O.)
Not to win. To end.

It's a memory? A projection? Doesn't matter.

Ravi staggers. Grey Vulture hesitates, visibly shaken.

He drops his blade. Kneels. The child offers the urn.

Ravi pours the ash. Not over Vulture, but into the glyph center.

A BURNING SIGIL rises, Ravi's, and then slowly DISINTEGRATES.

RAVI
I reject the scale.

Silence.

GREY VULTURE
So be it.

The glyphs SHATTER, collapsing the chamber into ash and light.

Ravi falls, smiling through blood.

CUT TO:

INT. TRIAL CHAMBER - UNKNOWN TIME

The air is thick now. Not just ash, but heat. Humidity. Ritual weight.

The glyphs around the chamber walls PULSE like a heartbeat.

Ravi stands at the center. Shaky. Bleeding. Changed.

A CRACK splits the stone near the throne. ASH pours upward. REVERSE GRAVITY.

From it, GREY VULTURE steps through.

Not ghost. Not god. Not man. Curator of ruin.

GREY VULTURE
She was never building a future.
She was selecting the one who'd bury it.

RAVI
She chose wrong.

GREY VULTURE
She chose... inevitability.

He unsheathes a weapon, jagged, ceremonial. Like it was never meant for clean killing.

The door seals behind them with a hum. Glyphs flare red.

WHISPERS (V.O.)
Trial duel initiated.

A ripple through the chamber. The FLOOR PLATES rotate subtly. Lock into place.

Ravi draws a blade. Steadies his breath.

GREY VULTURE
No more prophecy. No more revenge.
Just finality.

The DUEL BEGINS.

Ravi and Vulture COLLIDE.

The rhythm is different from before. Not chaos, ritual precision.

Clash. Parry. Slam.

Each impact causes a GLYPH to flicker somewhere on the wall.

VULTURE'S BLADE scrapes Ravi's shoulder, not deep, but intentional.

Ravi tackles him into a wall, smashing a RELIC MASK embedded there. It SCREAMS as it cracks.

The scream ECHOES like an alarm — triggering.

The chamber warps. FLOOR SECTIONS sink. New ones rise.

TRAP RINGS ignite, each with relic ash in their center, glowing.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
They were never enemies, you know. The names you carved, they were predecessors.

RAVI
You talk too much.

He HURLS a broken glyph shard, it hits a trap ring, and the pulse knocks both of them sideways.

They rise again. Bleeding. Winded. Still circling.

VULTURE lunges, lands a strike to Ravi's ribs. Ravi grabs the blade into himself — holding it.

RAVI (CONT'D)
(hoarse)
Enough.

Ravi JERKS the blade from his own gut and drives it into VULTURE'S shoulder, pinning him into the ash wall.

Vulture snarls. Laughs.

GREY VULTURE
You can't kill what was designed to outlive you.

Then — the chamber dims.

A SOFT BLUE LIGHT begins to glow from the ash pit.

A relic HOLOGRAPHIC FIGURE forms.

It's ALINA. Silent. Watching. Not a message. Just presence.

GREY VULTURE (CONT'D)
She came to see you fall.

But Alina's gaze is soft. Sad. The weight of every mistake.

Ravi's knees nearly buckle.

He pulls a FLINT relic from his belt. Scratches fire.

Holds it to his own glyph, etched on his arm.

The FLAMES CONSUME IT.

The glyph SCREAMS, but no sound leaves Ravi's mouth.

Grey Vulture stares, stunned —

As the glyphs all around the chamber begin to BURN OUT.

ASH rains from the ceiling, not like smoke. Like freedom.

The trial collapses.

Light overtakes the chamber.

INT. ASHFIELD RUINS - EDGE OF THE TRIAL CHAMBER - PRE-DAWN

The remnants of the duel chamber still whisper. Columns cracked. Glyphs burnt out. Silence reigns, thick as smoke.

Ravi emerges from a broken threshold, blood dried black across his side. One arm clutches a makeshift wrap at his ribs —

Each step is deliberate. Not limping, reclaiming.

The ash underfoot is no longer humming.

CUT TO:

EXT. ASHFIELD BLUFFS - DAWN

Golden light bleeds through low-hanging clouds. The horizon breathes. The hum is gone.

Ravi reaches the high bluff, an overlook of the outer zones. Below, scattered relic scavengers move through ruins.

He drops to one knee. Exhausted.

His hand reaches for his forearm. The branded GLYPH there, still faintly marked. Not burning anymore. Just scar tissue.

He takes a shard of flint. STRIKES it once.

Nothing.

He doesn’t strike again.

CUT TO:

EXT. DERELICT OUTSKIRTS - LATER

Ash floats on still air. The world feels paused. Ravi walks through a skeletal field of relic husks, shattered blades, cracked masks, scorched insignia. Each step echoes in this graveyard of belief.

Beyond a crumbling spine wall, A BAND OF KIDS, war-scarred, soot-faced, barefoot, watch silently. One boy, 15, stands slightly ahead. Wary. Not afraid.

Ravi stops a few paces away. Doesn’t speak. Just watches.

He removes a BURNT COIN from his belt, the old insignia of the Trial caste, now melted, twisted.

He kneels, sets it in the ash.

RAVI
(quiet)
You’ll know when it matters.

The boy’s eyes flicker. No recognition. Just understanding. Ravi turns. Walks on.

His silhouette dissolves into the heat shimmer.

CUT TO:

EXT. WET MARKET WALL - DUSK

A flicker of mural paint on old concrete. The cracked Scale glyph still visible, now split, bleeding pigment.

Beneath it, smeared in fresh blood and ash: A PALM. OPEN. EMPTY.

Below that, someone has scrawled in tiny glyphscript: "Nothing owned. Nothing owed."

CUT TO:

EXT. FAR BORDERLINE - NIGHT

A relic smuggler’s transport lurches through final checkpoint. Inside the dim hold: scattered relic shards, ration crates and Sahara.

Her hair is matted, her coat patched with ash banding. On her lap: a relic-bound journal, half-burnt, clasped with broken copper glyphwire.

She flips it open.

Written on the inside panel: RAVI - VANE - GREY VULTURE - ?

Her chalk hovers. Pauses. Doesn't write.

SAHARA
(softly)
Not yet.

She closes the journal. Sits back. Eyes forward as the vehicle vanishes into ashstorm.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED SHRINE - MIDNIGHT

Wind whips past fractured statues. A long-forgotten relic basin sits cracked at the center. Within, the remnants of the TRIAL MASK.

Smoke still coils from its fractures. Not voices. Not prophecy.

Just memory. Fading. But not silent.

CUT TO:

INT. TRIAL CHAMBER RUINS - PRE-DAWN

Stillness. Light seeps in like breath.

Footsteps echo.

Sahara enters the broken chamber. Her presence feels like a reckoning. She kneels where Ravi last bled. Touches the cooled ash.

Nearby, she finds his BLADE — split, jagged, half-buried. She lifts it gently.

FLASH CUT: Ravi, mid-duel, gripping the blade like truth. Then — gone.

CUT TO:

INT. RELIC HALL - MINUTES LATER

Glyphs flicker across the desecrated vault. Broken relics line the walls like extinct prayers. Sahara walks through them.

She reaches the Archive wall. A dozen LEDGERS — brittle, blood-stamped — teeter on collapsing shelves.

She pulls one. Reads a name. Her own.

She DRAWS A FLARE. STRIKES it.

Flames bloom. Ledger edges curl.

Behind her: CHILDREN. Former initiates. Survivors. Silent.

One speaks, a GIRL, maybe 13, holding a cracked bracer.

GIRL
What now?

SAHARA
(without hesitation)
What they feared we'd do.

She turns. Leads them out.

The Archive burns behind them.

CUT TO:

EXT. INNER CITY WALLS - DAWN

SERIES OF SHOTS:

— A hand paints a new symbol across a shattered statue: a BROKEN GLYPH, reformed into a circle.

— A woman tears down a Scale banner. Replaces it with a crimson sash.

— In a shadowed alley, a child chalks three words in multiple languages: "ASH DOESN'T ERASE US."

CUT TO:

INT. DEAD RADIO TOWER - LATER

Sparks stutter from an old comm unit, jury-rigged with relic coils and old bones.

SAHARA stands before it.

The static parts.

SAHARA
(into mic)
If you're alive, stay that way.

She hesitates. Then-

SAHARA (CONT'D (CONT'D)
What comes next... No one's prepared for.

She cuts the signal.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY EDGE - LATER

A slow, sweeping shot: BEACONS IGNITE — one after another — crimson smoke columns rising from the ruins.

This is no army. It's a signal swarm.

From watchpoints. From hollowed towers. From forgotten rooftops.

Children. Elders. Outcasts. Relic-burnt. Blood-marked. All lighting the fire.

Among them, Sahara. Still. Hood down now.

She doesn't lead.

She lit the match.

CUT TO:

EXT. EDGE OF THE WASTES - DUSK

Ravi limps across cracked earth. The trial chamber long behind him. A black scar on the horizon.

The ash is still now. No hum. No glow. Just wind and decay.

He kneels at a dead tree, more petrified bone than bark.

Ravi pulls something from his belt: a charred page. The top bears a SIGIL. Alina's mark.

He lights it with flint. The ink runs. The glyph bleeds. As it burns, the fire TWISTS the lines into a new shape, one with no translation.

Not language. Not prophecy. Just... something else.

FLAMES DIE. Ravi watches the ash drift.

He reaches into his pocket, pulls out a small CHARM, cracked and blackened. Mira's old trinket. Childlike. Cheap.

RAVI
(faintly, to the wind)
She believed before I did.

He sets it gently beside the dying coals. Doesn’t watch it burn. Just turns away.

He digs into his pouch, unrolls a strip of torn CLOTH.

It’s stained. Frayed. The same one Sahara used to bind his ribs.

He kneels. Wraps it around a stick. Drives it into the soil beside him. Not a grave. Not a flag. Just... placement.

A marker.

He unfastens the red armband from his wrist. Presses it against the cloth. Ties it there.

Last, his fingers tremble. He opens his palm.

The COIN. The one with the hole. The one Mael had, the one she gave him.

He studies it. Light filters through the center.

He digs. Just enough.

Buries it in DIRT, not ash.

Covers it. Presses his palm flat over it. A full beat of silence.

No vengeance. No prayer. Just... finality.

A wider shot —

Ravi sits alone. Charred, spent. Breathing.

The horizon doesn’t answer.

Suddenly. A faint, NEW sound.

Not ash hum. Not relic echo.

A BIRD CALL. Real. Organic. A life unbranded.

He lifts his face.

RAVI (CONT'D)
(quietly)
Still something left.

CUT TO:

EXT. COASTAL SCRAPYARD - TWILIGHT - UNKNOWN TIME

Rain slicks corrugated metal. Fog slithers low across wreckage. A shipbreaking yard long abandoned, now reclaimed by stray dogs and silent scavengers.

An INDUSTRIAL WALL, rust-bloated and blackened, flickers under the erratic blink of a sodium light.

A SMALL CHILD (genderless, grime-streaked) moves carefully between upturned hulls and shattered containers. No shoes. No words.

They stop. Still. Eyes fixed on something buried beneath damp soot.

FINGERTIPS brush away layers of filth.

A glint — a COIN. Weathered. Pitted. A perfect hole punched through the center.

THIS IS THE COIN — the same one once carried by RAVI, gifted to MAEL, buried in ash at the edge of ruin.

The child lifts it.

The distant SOUND of crashing waves fades.

SILENCE.

Then — a whisper not heard, but *felt*:

WHISPER (V.O.)
You are not alone.

The child turns.

A CRUMBLING WALL, scrawled with chalk sigils, bone marks, ritual burns.

At its center: a "new name." Not Ravi's. Something unfamiliar. Primitive. Claimed.

The child tucks the coin into a string necklace. Wipes their hands. Looks out to sea.

In the distant fog, a faint bell chimes.

The child's expression hardens. A decision made without words.

They turn away from the sea.

Toward firelight in the hills.

CUT TO:

EXT. SLAG MARKET - NIGHT

A crooked corridor carved beneath an overpass. Black tarps flutter in the wind, strung between rebar crucifixes. Neon signs flicker, not commerce, but warning.

00:14 AM

Heavy rain. Distant thunder. Burned-out glyphs flash faint pulses, remnants of defunct systems.

INT. MARKET TENT - CONTINUOUS

Steam rises from cracked grates. Figures sit on crates, weapons laid bare on silk. No names. Only marks.

A SCARRED STRANGER enters.

HOODED. SILENT. EYES UNBLINKING.

He carries a SATCHEL. Places it on a relic-weighed table.

Across from him. A KEEPER. Masked. Dozens of relics hang like talismans from her neck. She doesn’t speak.

The stranger opens the satchel.

INSIDE: a SINGLE PLATE. Old Scale metal. Blood-pocked. Etched with 14 NAMES. 13 scratched out.

The only name untouched: RAVI

A beat. The Keeper studies the name. Slides a COIN forward.

It’s not just any coin. It’s a duplicate of the original: HOLE-PUNCHED. Burnished.

The stranger takes it. Rolls it across his knuckles. Balanced.

He removes a blade. Places it on the table.

Clean. Custom. Brutal in shape. Ritual-carved.

THE KEEPER (WHISPERS)
This one’s different.

The stranger doesn’t answer.

A beat. Then — a fan of arterial spray blooms across the tiled wall behind the counter. No struggle. No scream. Just the soft creak… of a chair… slowly spinning.

COIN FLIPS.

SLOW MOTION:

It spins, caught in the flicker of dead glyph light, casting fractured shadows.

BACK TO:

He catches it. Palm closed.

A long pause.

The STRANGER opens his palm.

We don’t see the result.

He stands.

Exits into the rain.

EXT. MARKET EXIT - CONTINUOUS

He vanishes into smoke and blinking relic light.

CAMERA HOLDS.

On the coin. On the plate. On the name: RAVI

Etched. But no longer still.

A faint glow begins to spread from the name. A line. Then another. The glyph begins to fracture.

It’s changing.

Something new being written.

CUT TO BLACK.